

of Kotak under one narrative, one strategy, one kind of umbrella, so that when we go out aggressively and land things—and I think you’ll see a lot of those landings happening in the next calendar year—you’ll start seeing those come through. All the preparatory work that has been done in the past six to nine months will start showing up in the marketplace then.

Q: What is the state of your tech stack?

A: Tremendous amounts of work had to be done [and] has been done. But remember that technology is the new arms race. It is moving so fast that there is no question of taking a breather. But on basic things like resilience and cybersecurity, I think we’ve done a tremendous amount of work.

“My sense is that we are at the peak (of unsecured retail credit), and then it will taper off and we will come back to some level of normalcy two quarters down the road”

Q: When 811 was launched, it set off expectations. I don’t think it delivered on that. Is there a new 811 that you have in mind?

A: I don’t know why you don’t think it delivered. I think 811 has been a fantastic business for us... 811 was acquiring, before the technology embargo, about 600,000 accounts every single month. And just the sheer scale of acquisition... to do it at scale is amazing. Now, I think the fundamental thing that I wanted to drive when I got here, is this notion of how do you put the customer at the centre of everything that you do. So, let us take 811... as you know it was being marketed as a product that is like a savings product, [with the] ability to make payments very, very efficiently, not have a minimum balance on the savings account, open in a digital account in less than 3 minutes and all of that.

Q: And many of those things were brilliant...

A: The team delivered on all of them. So, to my mind, 811 was a tremendous success. But if you really think about 811 as an offering for core India, which also has a need for insurance, protection, investment, borrow-

ing... that completely changes the game. And now we have launched a new 811 app... and it stitches these journeys together. For the target customer—the core Indian customer—this is one place where you can get everything done smoothly, seamlessly and nicely. And from an economics point of view, it is great because you acquire a customer, and you can do much more with the customer rather than just one product. So, I am extremely excited about 811 and I cannot wait for us to get released from the embargo because then we will get back to those levels of acquisition with three or four product engines attached to the plane.

Q: Which of your products would you want to scale up rapidly?

A: The key focus for me is the customer. If I’ve learnt one thing in my 35 years, it is to get it right by the customer, [and] everything else will follow. Who is the customer that we are trying to go after and what is the proposition that I’m going to offer? So, where are we going to play, where are the areas of disproportionate attention? We have a fantastic top-rated private bank, [so] how do we get into affluent, NRI and core? We have got offerings against each one of those, it is about polishing those offerings, bringing all the products together to complement and make that offering strong, and then go after the customer.

Q: What do you think of India’s fintech industry?

The fintech sector is thriving in India. It is very encouraging to see how well they have done... some of them have grown and become serious companies of size and repute. The advantage fintech brings is a narrow focus and contemporary technology. The problem they have is how do you scale and how do you learn how to deal with the regulatory environment? We know what scale is. We know how to deal with the regulatory environment. We are obviously more broad-based. How do you bring that contemporary technology and kind of drive it? So, I think there is room for both. And there’s no reason why we can’t play that game. And there’s no reason why we can’t bring that technology to us, to our customers. I think it’s exhilarating.

Q: Uday Kotak said at one of our events that from a nation of savers, India is moving towards becoming a nation of investors. I want to link that to the deposit mobilisation challenge in the banking space. What is your view on this?